

Chapter

Is the Mind Greater, or the Body? — Mahakali and the Power of Protection



Introduction: The Pen or the Sword?

In spirituality we speak of the intellect, the mind and the soul, and we often treat the body as secondary. But where does the order of spiritual practice begin? In this short discourse, Acharya Upendra Ji raises a simple but important question — the body first, or the intellect first? — and answers it through the worship of the Goddess Mahakali.

Mahakali: The Goddess of Body-Awareness

At the very start, Acharya Ji makes clear the nature of Mahakali:

"Mahakali is the one of self-defence, the one of body-awareness. She first makes our body strong."

Why? Because our very sense of who we are begins with the body:

"Today, what do we see first — do we see the soul, or do we see the body? First, to be very frank, when I ask 'who am I?', isn't this the first thing that comes up — my name is so-and-so, this body is called such-and-such, I am dark, fair, tall, short?"

"Before anything else, that is what I see first; that is what gets importance. First I see the body. That is why Mahakali."

Spiritual practice begins where our journey begins — and that starting point is the body.

"Pen is mightier than the sword" — Really?

Acharya Ji draws attention to a famous English saying:

"We say 'pen is mightier than the sword' — the British said something like that, didn't they? That the pen is greater than the sword, and all sorts of things they say."

Our tradition, however, gives a different order:

"Open our Upanishads some time and look. Don't they say it — the body comes first, the intellect comes later? Who says this? Our Upanishads say it. Given a choice, first you need a body that is strong and powerful."

Intellect Alone Is Unprotected

Acharya Ji explains with a present-day example why the worship of Kali is taught first of all:

"Plenty of intellect came, people became scientists, made a formula — and then some other fellow came along, a thug, without any intellect, put a gun to your head: 'Give me your formula.'"

"You composed a poem; someone else pirated it and took it away. It can be stolen in a minute."

So intellect by itself is not enough:

"That intellectual alone is of no use. Along with that, by the body — and that means not only the physical body — brother, you need to be strong by whatever means."

Strength does not mean muscle power alone; strength is the ability to protect what you have created.

Sound mind in a sound body

Different traditions have said the same thing:

"This is what they tell us: sound mind in a sound body, that is what has been said. Swami Vivekananda said, 'First play football, then you will understand Vedanta.'"

And the same thought appeared long before, in the Chandogya Upanishad:

**annamayam hi somya mana āpomayaḥ
prāṇastejomayī vāgiti**

"O gentle one, the mind is made of food, the breath of water, and speech of fire."

— Chandogya Upanishad 6.5.4

Acharya Ji tells the story from this Upanishad:

"Aruni Uddalaka tells exactly this to Shvetaketu, his disciple: go without food for fifteen days, and then tell me what happens. He stays hungry for fifteen days, the body keeps wasting away, he cannot recite even one mantra, he gets dizzy and so on."

(Shvetaketu was Uddalaka's son as well as his disciple.)
Acharya Ji puts the conclusion of this experiment like this:

"They say: the first strength is physical. And protection — whatever is yours, its protection — is absolutely essential."

That is why, in the worship of the Goddess too, Kali has the first place. The **first charitra** (episode) of the Durga Saptashati is that of Mahakali:

"The worship of Kali is the first worship; even the first charitra is Kali's. Now do you understand why?"

Kali Shakti in Today's Life

This teaching is not limited to ancient stories. Acharya Ji brings it straight into the world of business:

"Suppose you started a company. First of all it will expand — that will surely be the feeling, won't it — it will grow big. 'Think big' — Shri Vidya says, think big."

But along with growth comes opposition:

"Fine, think big; but what must its consequences be?
'Consequence... conflict of the gunas' — enemies are
bound to come."

And that is exactly where the need for Kali Shakti is felt:

"I must immediately do copyright, trademarks, all of
this, patents. That is Kali Shakti. This much intelligence
must come: that I have to protect things first."

"Not the sword first — legal protection. My organisation
grows a little more, and don't you need to keep a
watchman?"

**Kali Shakti does not mean violence; it is the awareness to
protect what is growing, at the right time and in the right
way.**

Guarding the Yagna: Rama and Lakshmana

Acharya Ji recalls an episode from the Ramayana — the sages' fire-sacrifice and its guardians:

"When the yagna was to be performed, the rishi told Shri Rama: 'Rama and Lakshmana, you come, and stand there with bow and arrows. Maharaj, the rakshasas come.'"

From this he draws a clear principle:

"To do non-violent things, you need violent people around you. If you want to do the work of non-violence, you need people capable of force beside you."

"That means the Kshatriya — that is, the police, the army and our security guards — they are essential. And that is Kali."

A yagna, a sadhana, knowledge — no sacred work survives without protection.

Summary: The Main Teachings

- 1 Mahakali is the Goddess of body-awareness and self-protection.** Our identity begins with the body, so spiritual practice also begins there.
- 2 First the body, then the intellect.** The order of the Upanishads differs from "pen is mightier than the sword" — first the body must be strong and powerful.
- 3 Intellect alone is unprotected.** A formula, a poem, an idea — without protection, anyone can snatch it away in a minute.
- 4 The mind is made of food.** The story of Uddalaka and Shvetaketu in the Chandogya Upanishad shows that when the body wastes away, even a mantra cannot be recalled.
- 5 The worship of Kali is the first worship.** The first charitra of the Durga Saptashati is also Mahakali's.
- 6 In today's world, Kali Shakti means protection —** copyright, trademarks, patents, legal protection, watchmen.

7 **The work of non-violence needs guardians.** Just as Rama and Lakshmana guarded the yagna, today it is the police, the army and security guards — and that is Kali.